

TWO KINGDOMS — CHURCH AND STATE?

The Founders weren't afraid of too much church. They were afraid of too much power.

When the Bible teaches that God engages the World for the sake of the world in two distinct ways, modern people tend to hear “separation of Church and State” – as if the Church needs to keep quiet in the public sphere of American culture. The Bible teaches no such thing, however, and the American Founding Fathers weren’t afraid of too much “church” in society. They were afraid of too much power being amassed in the state.

So, what’s the point? Well, when talking about “Church and State,” remember that both the Church and the State are public entities under God’s authority and direction. The “state,” however, doesn’t just include politics and law enforcement. Rather, it is the public ordering of the world for the sake of civility, temporal justice, and peace, and that also includes the vocations of Father and Mother (families), and even the value and purpose of work and enterprise. That means all the various ways in which people seek to serve those they love with honest enterprise and committed friendship are also part of the “state”. When these things are ordered well, the Bible says that “Believers strive for excellence in all they do to give God glory and to serve others in His Name.” Thus, a well-ordered state will seek not to silence the church and keep it out of the public sphere, but to set believers free to strive for excellence and to serve others for the good of the whole society.

Of all the dispositions and habits which lead to political prosperity, religion and morality are indispensable supports.

GEORGE WASHINGTON, FAREWELL ADDRESS ¹

The American Founding Fathers understood this well. Washington and the other Founders knew that a well-ordered society is impossible without a virtuous citizenry, and they knew that the church is indispensable for encouraging such public morality. In a well-ordered society, therefore, the state seeks to protect the church’s involvement in the public sphere so that it can contribute to the moral education of the citizens and, in turn, to the preservation of society.

The idea of “Separation of Church and State” wasn’t to keep these beneficial aspects of the church out of the public sphere, rather it was to prevent the concentration of too much power in one institution. The Founding Fathers didn’t want a society without a church, they wanted political and religious power to be separated into distinct institutions, church and state, which would mutually support each other in support of the public good.

The Two-Kingdom view of life, then, sees the wonderful value of a government working well within its boundaries, and the powerful potential of a church that is set free to proclaim the Gospel

unrestrained. To that end, a Christian Two-Kingdom citizen, is “Set Free, to live freely for others in Christ.” They are ready to put their “Temporal liberties to work to proclaim and embody the eternal liberties of Christ,” just as the Apostle Paul put his Roman Citizenship to work for the Gospel in Acts 16.

TALK IT THROUGH

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Work through these with your group, then with a friend or your spouse — without the sheet.

- 1 What is the danger of the left-hand kingdom amassing too much power over the right-hand kingdom?

- 2 What is the danger of the right-hand kingdom amassing too much power over the left-hand kingdom?

- 3 What does it mean to put your temporal liberties to work for the Gospel?

¹ billofrightsinstitute.org/primary-sources/washingtons-farewell-address